The thousands of mourners gathered under a clear blue sky in Jerusalem in January 2015 were given a stark and seemingly contradictory message. European Jews shouldn't be forced to flee their countries, but they probably should flee anyway.

President Rivlin was the first to speak at the funeral of four Jews who had been gunned down at a kosher supermarket in Paris. The shooting had shocked France's Jewish community, the largest in Europe and the third-largest in the world. It had followed a steadily intensifying spate of anti-Semitic acts over the previous few years: synagogues and Jewish-owned businesses firebombed, families in religious garb attacked on the streets. In a grim coincidence, the victims of the attack at the Hyper Cacher market were buried in the same cemetery as the four people killed in a 2012 shooting at a Jewish day school in Toulouse.

Rivlin implored France to do more to protect its Jewish citizens, and spoke powerfully about the right of Jews to live in any country, in peace. "Returning to your ancestral home need not be due to distress, out of desperation, because of destruction, or in the throes of terror and fear," Rivlin said. He was followed at the pulpit by Prime Minister Netanyahu, who quickly contradicted him. "Our president was right when he said that Jews have the right to live in many countries," Netanyahu said. "But I believe they know deep in their hearts that they have only one country, the state of Israel, the historic homeland that will accept them with open arms."

This sort of language was a constant source of friction with the Soviet Union. More recently, Ariel Sharon sparked a diplomatic crisis in 2004 when he told French Jews to flee a country plagued by what he called "the wildest anti-Semitism". Then-president Jacques Chirac told Sharon he was not welcome to visit France until he explained his comments. The controversy didn't stop Netanyahu from echoing him.

Yet the fact is that Israel is a nation of immigrants. Since the country was founded in 1948, some 2.7 million Jews have made *aliyah*, a Hebrew word that literally means "to ascend". They came in waves: hundreds of thousands of Holocaust survivors who left the ruins of Europe; more than half a million Arab and North African Jews who fled, or were expelled; and then the great exodus of nearly a million Soviet Jews after Mikhail Gorbachev finally opened the borders. Today, however, the great waves of immigration seem to be finished.